records and documents, nor were any questions raised about the absence of stringent forensic procedures and criteria pertaining to the recovery of data from these documents. Court records show that the phone records relevant to the conversations between Afsan Guru and Shaukat or to certain conversations that Geelani is said to have had that were produced by the police as evidence (after much dithering) are actually of the days 'after' they were detained. Not a single newspaper or television news programme in those days, or in the early days of the trial in the special POTA court, could exhibit the necessary degree of reticence or patience required in the handling of a case as sensitive as this one. If the investigating authorities or the prosecution or the police said that phone records said something, no one actually asked to see the phone records, or to examine the dates, let alone the content of what transpired. The fact that the death sentences handed out by the POTA court were on the basis of false, forged, or inadmissible or absent evidence was not remarked upon by any news channel. A notable exception, however, which should not go unremarked is the reportage of the case in the *Hindu*, which, barring a stray story in the early days, was marked by balanced and fair reporting, especially the reports filed from the court by Anjali Mody which even subjected other media reports of the case to some degree of critical scrutiny.

Finally, when the defence asked for the phone records to be produced and examined by independent and knowledgeable witnesses, what came to light were discrepancies in translation and transcription. The fact that the translated sentence 'It becomes necessary sometimes' ('*yeh kabhi kabhi zaroori hota hai*'), apparently said in response to a question about 'what has happened in Delhi' , which Geelani said referred to a domestic dispute and which the prosecution claimed was about the attack on Parliament, and on which hinged the entire structure of the case against S.A.R. Geelani, was not found to be audible in the tape of the phone intercept when it was played repeatedly for the benefit of the two independent defence witnesses—a documentary film-maker, Sanjay Kak, and a trade union activist, Sampath Prakash, both native Kashmiri speakers.

It needs to be mentioned that while the media attention on S.A.R. Geelani, as the 'intellectual preceptor' of the terrorists, was particularly intense, it was less so with regard to Mohammad Afzal, the man whose 'confession' in detention, an instrument inadmissible in ordinary law as evidence (although